

An Autistic Student at Your Workplace (Intern / Part-Time Job)

For managers, supervisors & colleagues — working with an autistic student in a part-time job, internship or placement.

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a student's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." A part-time job or internship can be a real strength area — depth, reliability, honesty, attention to detail — but the student is often juggling it alongside an already-overloading university life. Clear expectations, written instructions, fewer interruptions and a predictable routine let them contribute well and build confidence, and may be the difference between a promising placement and a student who burns out.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Brilliant at one task; "checks out" at others	Deep, single-track focus — channel it, don't fight it
Wants instructions in writing; avoids the open-plan chat	Single-channel communication reduces the load
Doesn't "do" small talk or socials	High social load, not rudeness or disinterest
Misses unwritten rules; asks blunt questions	Literal communication — engagement, not awkwardness
Flags or burns out mid-placement	Cumulative load tipping into burnout

Try this

- **Be explicit about expectations, norms and "unwritten rules"** — say what good looks like, in writing.
- **Offer written instructions and asynchronous options**; batch meetings; protect focus time.
- **Play to the strength** — give defined, depth-friendly tasks; the "tunnels, not tasks" principle.
- **Give literal, concrete feedback** — kind, clear, specific; avoid hinting.
- **Check in on load** — a placement alongside study is a lot; flexibility prevents burnout.

Avoid this

- Vague briefs, surprise changes, or "you should just know" expectations.
- Mandatory loud socials or networking with no low-key alternative.
- Equating quiet or a literal question with disengagement.

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout** (exhaustion, loss of skills, reduced tolerance) — it's common in students juggling work and study. Signpost the university disability service and, where you offer them, occupational health or an employee-assistance programme. A reduced-hours arrangement is a legitimate support, not failure.

If the student is a woman

Late-identified women mask intensely and may look “fine” while privately exhausted; take reduced tolerance and withdrawal seriously, however capable they appear.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.4), the **Family guide** (Part 4) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Knight (2021, *tunnels not tasks*); Booth (2021, work & autistic people); Raymaker et al. (2020). Full citations are in the source drafts.